

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TUNISIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to land, water, and resources in Tunisia, and one desert sit-in showed the country exactly how much power an organised community holds. In 2017, in the marginalised southern governorate of Tataouine, where nearly a third of people had no work, a movement of mostly young men did something the powerful never expected: they walked out into the desert, occupied the **El Kamour** pumping station that carries about half of Tunisia's crude oil, and shut the valve. They organised themselves without leaders a government could arrest or buy, camped in the sand through the heat, and refused to turn the oil back on until the state listened. In June 2017, brokered by the country's great trade union, the **UGTT**, they forced the government and the oil companies to sign an agreement: jobs for the region, and a development fund of eighty million dinars a year for Tataouine. A poor, forgotten region had reached into the pipeline that fed the capital and made the state come to the table. The details are worth setting down, because they show how deliberate it was. The movement began in March 2017 with protests across the Tataouine governorate, converging on demands for a share of the region's oil wealth, for jobs, and for development; met at first with silence, the protesters organised a sit-in at the remote El Kamour station, about a hundred and ten kilometres out in the desert, and in May they occupied it. The agreement they won that June committed the oil companies to hire fifteen hundred people from the region, the state to employ thousands more over three years, and the government to set aside eighty million dinars a year for Tataouine. It was not a spontaneous riot but a patient, organised campaign that used the one thing the region had — its grip on the infrastructure — to win what years of petitions had not.

The El Kamour story teaches two things about fighting here — including its hard limits, which this guide states from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the organised strength, the leverage, and the country's attention — pressed together until the powerful answer. The second is distinctly Tunisian, and it grew from a revolution. **In the young democracy that Tunisians won in 2011, an organised community can occupy the infrastructure, take to the streets, and force the state and the companies to the table** — to share the wealth of the resources taken from its land, to close a facility that poisons it, or to reclaim a commons. That power — the sit-in, the occupation, the mass protest, backed by a powerful trade union and a tradition of civic courage — is Tunisia's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. It is worth naming what made El Kamour work as an organising model, because it is copyable. The movement was led not by a single figure but by a coordination committee of about ten people representing the towns of the governorate, a flat structure chosen precisely so that the authorities could not decapitate the movement by arresting or buying one leader. Its participants were mostly young men who had lost faith in party politics and found, in a disciplined and largely peaceful occupation, a way to make the state listen that the ballot box had not given them. That combination — a just claim, a flat and unbreakable structure, and a hard point of leverage — is the Tunisian template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. El Kamour won **jobs and a fund, not an end to the drilling** — it was a fight to share the wealth, not to stop the extraction, and the guide is honest that this is often the realistic prize. The agreement was **implemented slowly and incompletely**, and the region had to rise again and again in the years that followed to demand what it had been promised. The protests were met by the **army and the police**, and people were hurt and killed. And the democratic opening that made such pressure work has, since 2021, **narrowed**, so the civic space a community relies on cannot be taken for granted. And the deeper problem beneath every such fight is real and unresolved: the marginalised interior and south have for generations sent their phosphate, their oil, and their labour to a coast that returned little, and no single agreement undoes that structural neglect. El Kamour did not end Tataouine's poverty or its unemployment; it won a promise of jobs and a fund, much of which then had to be wrung out slowly over the years that followed. A community should enter such a fight understanding that it is one battle in a long war over how a country shares what it takes from its poorest regions. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of an organised Tunisian community that occupies, protests, and forces the powerful to the table — and the slow implementation, the danger, and the narrowing space that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They watch the resources of their region flow to the coast and the capital, or a project poison their air and water, assume "the powerful have decided and nothing can be done," and never organise, never document, never occupy, never bring in the union, never force the negotiation. They generate private grievance without a public claim. The gap between a community that forces the state to the table and one that watches its wealth leave is rarely courage — Tunisians have shown extraordinary courage, from the revolution to

the desert. It is method: knowing that an organised, non-hierarchical community, backed by the union and the country's attention, can occupy the infrastructure and make the powerful answer.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Tunisian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a destructive project, close a polluting facility, or force a fair share of a region's resources:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision, the leverage, and the claim)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of the harm and the injustice)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(organise the community and the union)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES	(the courts, the law, and the negotiated agreement)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make it national)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case, the negotiation, and the public argument at once; the organised community sustains the pressure; an occupation or a protest is a headline and a headline builds the movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, a facility closed, or a fair share forced. The El Kamour movement did exactly this — it organised without arrestable leaders, documented the region's neglect, built its coalition, brought in the union, occupied the infrastructure, and carried its fight to the nation, until the state signed.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Tunisia's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Occupying the infrastructure.** A community can **occupy the site or the infrastructure** — the valve, the plant, the road — and make the extraction or the project stop until it is heard, as El Kamour shut the pipeline. This is the lever that most distinguishes the Tunisian repertoire, and its logic is simple: a project that depends on a single chokepoint — a pumping station, a processing plant, an access road, a rail line — hands the community that can physically reach and hold that point a power out of all proportion to its wealth or numbers. When the El Kamour station stopped, roughly half the country's crude stopped with it, and a government that had ignored the region for years suddenly had a pressing reason to negotiate. Identifying and, where justified, holding such a chokepoint is often the single most decisive thing a Tunisian community can do.
- **The UGTT and organised labour.** The **Tunisian General Labour Union** is a powerful national force that can **mediate, guarantee agreements, and lend organised strength** — a distinctive ally that helped win and hold the world's respect in 2015. The UGTT is not an ordinary union; it is one of the most powerful institutions in the country, with a reach into every region and sector and a history of national leadership stretching back to the independence struggle. It was a central member of the national dialogue that steered Tunisia through its most dangerous political crisis and that was recognised with the Nobel Peace Prize, and it has repeatedly served as the broker who can bring a protesting community and a reluctant government to the same table and then stand as guarantor of what they agree. For a community in a fight, an alliance with the union is among the most valuable assets available anywhere in the Tunisian system.
- **Non-hierarchical organisation.** A **flat, participatory coordination committee**, with no single leader to arrest or buy, resists repression and co-optation, as El Kamour's did.
- **Mass protest and the sit-in.** In a country forged by a revolution, **street protest and the sit-in** are a real and practised lever the state must reckon with.
- **The claim to the region's resources and health.** A community's claim to a **fair share of its resources** and to a **clean and healthy environment** is a powerful, unifying cause.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always stop projects. El Kamour **won a share, not a stop**. Agreements are **implemented slowly**, if at all. Protest can be **dangerous**, met by force. And the **civic space has narrowed** since the democratic opening. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — organising the community, occupying where you must, bringing in the union, and forcing the powerful to the table, as El Kamour forced them.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision — or the leverage — is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Tunisian development or extraction project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the ministries. The **national government and its ministries** — energy, environment, industry — approve projects, grant permits, and sign agreements. This is often the proponent, and the body a community forces to the table.

The companies. Oil, mining, and development companies, foreign and domestic, operate the projects and depend on the infrastructure a community can occupy. These companies are a distinct pressure point from the government, and sometimes a more sensitive one: they answer to shareholders and to production targets, a prolonged stoppage costs them directly, and they will often press the government to settle with a community precisely because their own operations are being interrupted. During the El Kamour occupation the operating companies warned that a continued shutdown could force them to halt production entirely, and that pressure from the industry on the state was part of what moved the negotiation. A community should understand that an occupation squeezes the companies and the government at once, and that the companies' own interest in resuming production can become a lever.

The local authorities. Governors and local officials administer the region and are the state's nearest face — and sometimes the first to negotiate.

The courts. Tunisian **courts** can review permits and defend rights, a real if slower lever.

The community, the union, and civil society. The **organised community, the UGTT, and civil society** are the force that documents, occupies, protests, and forces the negotiation — the level that won at El Kamour.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government decision and a **permit or contract**, through the **companies** that build and operate it, administered by **local authorities**, toward extraction or construction — with the **community, the union, and civil society** able to document, occupy, protest, and negotiate at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Tunisian doors are the **occupation of the infrastructure** and the **organised protest backed by the union**, which forced the state at El Kamour. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **what leverage you hold** — the valve, the site, the road, the region's labour — because that leverage is what brings the powerful to the table.

Follow the Project, the Resources, and the Harm

Behind the project stand a proponent — the government, a company, or both — and the officials who approved it. Trace who profits, who decided, and — critically in Tunisia — **where the resources and the wealth go, what the project does to the community's land, water, air, and health, and what the region is owed and denied.** Two questions unlock most Tunisian fights: **What leverage does the community hold over the project — the infrastructure, the site, the labour?** and **What is the region owed — a fair share of its resources, a clean environment, the jobs and development it was promised?** The leverage and the claim are, together, the heart of most Tunisian campaigns. The two work together in a specific way: the claim — that the region is owed a share of its wealth, or a clean environment, or the jobs it was promised — gives the fight its justice and its power to unite people and move the nation, while the leverage — the chokepoint, the labour, the occupation — gives it the force that turns a just claim into a signed agreement. A campaign with a just claim but no leverage may be ignored; one with leverage but no clear claim may be dismissed as extortion; El Kamour had both, a documented grievance and a hand on the pipeline, and a modern campaign should build both.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **courts**, slower but real; the **UGTT**, which mediates and guarantees; **civil society and the associations** that document and organise; the **national and international press**; and the **organised, mobilised community** itself, the ultimate lever, which shut the pipeline at El Kamour. In Tunisia, the **occupation and protest backed by the union** are the most distinctive and

decisive levers, because they force the state and the companies to negotiate where petitions alone would not. Each is a separate front, and a project that harms a community, that denies a region its due, and that faces an organised occupation backed by the union rarely escapes the negotiating table. You do not have to choose one front: the same organised community can hold the occupation, bring in the union, document the injustice for the press and the courts, and carry its claim to the nation all at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others. A Tunisian campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the occupation that forces the table and the union that guarantees the outcome as the two that reach furthest — the one applying the pressure, the other converting it into a commitment that holds.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Tunisian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community **holds real leverage** over the project (the infrastructure, the site, the labour), whether it can **organise without arrestable leaders**, whether the **UGTT and civil society** stand with it, whether it can **sustain an occupation or protest**, and whether it can carry the fight to the **nation**. Where a community holds the leverage and organises well, Tunisia's occupation-and-protest levers are real, as El Kamour showed; but temper every figure with the knowledge that the win may be a share or a closure, not a full stop, and that implementation may be slow.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Occupying the infrastructure / site	35–60%	weeks–months	low–moderate	The state and companies to the table
Mass protest & the sit-in	30–55%	ongoing	low	Pressure the state cannot ignore
UGTT & union backing	35–60%	varies	low	Mediation, guarantee, organised strength
Non-hierarchical organisation	30–55%	ongoing	low	A movement resistant to repression
Legal challenge	15–40%	years	low–moderate	Delay; a permit reviewed; the record
The negotiated agreement	35–60%	months	low	Jobs, a fund, a closure, a fair share
Media & national attention	35–60%	ongoing	low	The nation engaged; pressure raised
All steps (real leverage + union + organised community)	40–65%	months–years	low–moderate	A stop, a closure, or a fair share forced
All steps (little leverage / narrowed space)	20–45%	months–years	low–moderate	Delay; partial concession; the record

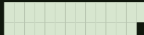
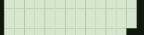
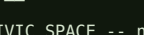
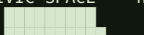
Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Tunisia's real strengths are distinctive — **occupying the infrastructure, the UGTT and organised labour, non-hierarchical organisation, mass protest**, and the **claim to the region's resources and health**. Its constraints are specific: the win is often a **share or a closure, not a full stop**; **implementation is slow**; protest can be **dangerous**; and the **civic space has narrowed**.

A note on cost: organising the community, occupying a site, and protesting cost little but courage and endurance, and the union's backing is a matter of alliance, not money. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the discipline to organise without arrestable leaders and the endurance to hold an occupation or a protest until the state comes to the table — exactly what El Kamour required.

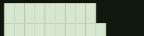
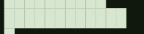
Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (stopped, closed, or a fair share forced)

REAL LEVERAGE + UNION BACKING + AN ORGANISED, NON-HIERARCHICAL COMMUNITY:

All steps combined:		40-65%
Occupation + union:		35-60%
The negotiated agreement:		35-60%
Protest + national media:		30-60%
Single step:		5-60%

LITTLE LEVERAGE / NARROWED CIVIC SPACE -- no valve to shut, protest constrained:

All steps combined:		20-45%
Occupation where possible:		the reach a community still holds
Delay / partial concession:		more achievable than a full stop
Single step:		5-40%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Tunisia are **the occupation and the organised protest backed by the union**, amplified by non-hierarchical organisation and the national press. El Kamour shows the ceiling: a poor region shut the pipeline and forced the state to sign. But the limits show the floor: the win was a share, not a stop; implementation was slow; and the space has narrowed. Most Tunisian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the occupation and the union are real, distinctive, and powerful levers — decisive when a community holds leverage and organises well, weaker when it holds little, where the realistic win is delay, a partial concession, and a record. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a community sitting on a chokepoint the whole economy depends on, organised and backed by the union, is in the strong band and can aim high; a community with no such leverage, in a narrowed civic space, is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a partial concession, and a record that a later, better-positioned campaign can build on. Honesty about which band you are in keeps a campaign from promising what it cannot deliver and from missing what it can.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Occupying the infrastructure and organising the protest** — Tunisia's most distinctive lever; the sit-in and the occupation that force the state and the companies to the table, as at El Kamour.
2. **The UGTT and organised labour** — the union's mediation, guarantee, and organised strength, which brokered and held the El Kamour agreement.
3. **Non-hierarchical, participatory organisation** — the flat coordination committee, with no leader to arrest or buy, that resists repression.
4. **The negotiated agreement and the legal record** — turning the leverage into a signed commitment on jobs, a fund, a closure, or a fair share, and defending it.
5. **Media and national attention** — the coverage that engages the nation and raises the cost of ignoring the community.

What Tunisian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Leverage forces the table** — El Kamour shut the pipeline and the state came. **The union matters** — the UGTT brokered and guaranteed. **Flat organisation resists repression** — no leader to arrest. **Protest can close a facility** — Agareb's protests shut a landfill that poisoned it. **But wins are often partial** — a share, a closure, slowly implemented, not a full stop. The through-line: **find your leverage; organise without arrestable leaders; bring in the union; occupy or protest; and force the negotiated agreement — because in Tunisia an organised community that holds the infrastructure can make the powerful answer.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and the leverage the community holds over it, which in Tunisia is often the infrastructure or the region's labour. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the oil that flows from our land while we have no work, and the pumping station we can shut until we get our share" is a campaign — the campaign El Kamour won. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What leverage does the community hold? This is the first Tunisian question, because leverage is what forces the table. Can the community **occupy the infrastructure** — the valve, the plant, the site, the road — or withhold the **labour** the project needs, as El Kamour shut the pumping station? Find the pressure point. Do this first and coldly, because everything else in a Tunisian campaign is shaped by the answer: a community with a hard chokepoint plays one game, aiming to force a full negotiation, while a community without one plays another, leaning harder on documentation, the union, the courts, and national opinion to build pressure it cannot apply physically. Do not assume you have no leverage

until you have looked carefully — the point may be a pumping station, but it may equally be an access road, a rail line, a processing plant, a port, or the region's own labour, without which the project cannot run.

2. What is the region owed, and denied? Is the community denied a **fair share of its resources**, the **jobs and development** it was promised, or a **clean and healthy environment**? This is the claim that unites the community and justifies the fight. The strength of a resource-justice claim in Tunisia is that it rests on a proposition few can honestly dispute: that a region which produces a nation's wealth should not be left in poverty and neglect, and that the people whose land bears the extraction have a rightful claim on its benefits. Framed that way — not as a demand for charity but as a claim for a fair share of what is already being taken from the region — the cause unites the community across its divisions and wins sympathy across the country, because it appeals to a sense of fairness the revolution made central to Tunisian public life.

3. What does it do to the land, water, air, and health? What **harm** does the project cause — the pollution, the poisoned air or water, the health toll, as at Agareb — and what does the community stand to lose?

4. Will the UGTT and civil society stand with it? Can the **union and the associations** be brought in to mediate, guarantee, and lend strength, as the UGTT did at El Kamour?

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which ministry or company is behind it, who profits, where the wealth goes; which communities and lands are affected; and which courts, unions, associations, media, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose the resources of a marginalised region flow to the capital and to foreign companies while the region has no work, and the community can reach the pumping station that carries them.

Working the five questions: what **leverage** does the community hold — the station, the pipeline, the road? What is the region **owed and denied** — a share, jobs, development? What **harm** does the extraction do? Will the **UGTT and civil society** stand with it? And the deciders are the government and the companies, with the courts, the union, the press, and the nation as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "our wealth leaves and we get nothing" to a target list: organise the community without arrestable leaders; document the neglect and the harm; bring in the union; occupy the infrastructure; and force the negotiated agreement. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how El Kamour won. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse sense of grievance into a short list of concrete tasks — organise the region, document the injustice, bring in the union, hold the chokepoint, force the deal — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin now. That reframing, from lament to leverage, is the difference the five questions make in Tunisia, and the first of them, what leverage the community holds, is usually the one that determines whether the fight can be won at all.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, a mediator, a journalist, and the nation all move on evidence, not indignation — and a community's claim to its resources and its health is far stronger when it is documented. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Contracts, and the Resource Flow

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **permits, contracts, and licences**, and — critically in Tunisia — trace **where the resources and the wealth go**: how much the region produces, how little it receives, how many of its people the project employs. Document the **promises made** — the jobs, the development, the fund — and whether they were kept, because the gap is the claim, as the unmet promises drove El Kamour's return again and again. The gap between what the region gives and what it gets is where the fight is justified. This resource-flow accounting is the distinctive documentation task of a Tunisian resource-justice fight, and it is worth doing rigorously: how much oil, gas, or phosphate the region produces, what that is worth, how many of the region's own people the industry employs, and how much of the revenue returns to the region in jobs, services, or development. Set beside the region's unemployment and neglect, that accounting is the case, because it turns a felt injustice into a documented one that the union can carry, a court can weigh, and the nation can understand at a glance.

Layer 2: The Harm and the Neglect

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **community's land, health, and neglect** at the centre. Record the **harm** — the pollution, the poisoned air or water, the health toll, as at Agareb — and the **neglect**: the unemployment, the failing infrastructure, the development that never came. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from those who live the harm and the neglect. This is the human case that unites the community and moves the nation. Give this layer particular care where the harm is to health, because a documented health toll — the illnesses clustered around a polluting plant, the fouled water, the poisoned air — is among the most powerful facts a community can present, moving people who might be unmoved by an abstract environmental argument. It was the lived experience of a facility poisoning its community that drove the Agareb protests to force a closure, and a campaign that documents such harm carefully, with dates, images, and testimony, arms itself with a case that is hard for any authority to dismiss and easy for the public to grasp.

Layer 3: The Claim, the Harm, and the Broken Promise

Finally, document the case for the fight. Is the region **denied its fair share** of the resources taken from its land? Is the **harm to health and environment** real and documented, as at Agareb? Were **promises made and broken** — jobs, a fund, development? Each is a separate ground — for the negotiation, the legal challenge, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Tunisian fights, because here a region sold as fairly treated is revealed to give its wealth and receive neglect, to bear the harm, and to have been promised what it never got — exactly the case El Kamour made. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the denied share, the documented harm, the broken promise — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the denied share drives the resource-justice negotiation, the harm drives the environmental and health case in the courts and the press, and the broken promise drives the demand for enforcement. A community that documents only one leaves levers unused; one that documents all three arms every part of its campaign from a single, well-kept file, and can shift its emphasis as the fight moves from occupation to negotiation to the long struggle for delivery.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Tunisian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that prove the harm, the neglect, and the broken promise.

The Project, the Resources, and the Paper Trail

- **The permits and contracts** — how the project was authorised, and on what terms.
- **The resource and revenue figures** — how much the region produces and how little it receives, the heart of a resource-justice claim.
- **The employment record** — how many of the region's people the project employs, against what was promised.
- **The promises and agreements** — the jobs, the fund, the development pledged, as in the El Kamour agreement, and whether they were kept.
- **The company** — the operator, foreign or domestic, its obligations and its record.

How to Get Them

Permit, contract, and revenue records come through the authorities and Tunisia's access-to-information framework, and through the ministries and the company; the employment and promise records through the same and through the community's own count. Lean on **allies**: Tunisia's investigative journalists and civil-society associations, the **UGTT**, which knows the labour and the industry, and the regional coordination committees that track what was promised. Move as the fight allows: documenting the neglect and the broken promises before and during an occupation gives the negotiation its evidence, as El Kamour's documented grievances gave its committee a case to bring to the table.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — the pollution, the poisoned air or water, the health toll, dated and photographed, as at Agareb.
- **The neglect** — the unemployment, the failing infrastructure, the absent development.
- **The resource flow** — what leaves the region and what stays.
- **The broken promises** — what was pledged and never delivered.
- **Testimony** — from those who live the harm and the neglect, and who know the region.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the permits, the promises, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any negotiation or challenge. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a union mediator, a journalist, a judge, and a minister at the negotiating table all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company or the ministry pushes back. In a country where an organised community can force the powerful to the table, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest record of what it gives, what it is denied, and what it was promised — is very often the one that wins the better agreement.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE THE COMMUNITY AND THE UNION

Evidence and leverage do not win on their own. Organised people do — and in Tunisia, El Kamour proved that a community organised without arrestable leaders, backed by the union, can force the state to the table. A Tunisian campaign's strength is that organisation: flat, disciplined, united, and allied with the UGTT.

Phase 1: The Core and the Flat Structure

Start with a committed core, but build it deliberately **flat and participatory** — a **coordination committee** drawn from across the affected communities, with no single leader for the state to arrest, buy, or blame, as El Kamour's ten-person committee spread its leadership to resist repression. Assign roles by function — documentation, union liaison, legal, media, and the organisation of the occupation or protest — and rotate them. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the facility closed, or the fair share forced — and on what the community will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition and the Union

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the **whole affected region**, so its towns and villages speak as one, as El Kamour's committee united the governorate; the **UGTT**, whose mediation, guarantee, and organised strength are Tunisia's distinctive ally; the **civil-society associations** that document and organise; sympathetic **lawyers and journalists**; and the **wider public**, for whom a marginalised region's claim to its resources or its health is a cause the revolution made resonant. Reach the **national and international press**, whose attention raises the cost of ignoring the community. El Kamour drew its power from exactly this breadth — a united region, the union, civil society, and the nation's attention — which is precisely the spread a winning Tunisian campaign needs. The way El Kamour united a whole governorate is itself a model: rather than a single town acting alone, the coordination committee drew in representatives from across the region's towns and cities, so that the movement spoke for the whole area and could not be split by settling with one community and neglecting another. A campaign that unites the entire affected region, and that ties that regional unity to the national reach of the union, presents the state with a problem it cannot solve by dividing, and that breadth is a large part of what forces a serious negotiation.

A worked coalition example. Facing the extraction of a region's wealth, the affected towns form the base and the flat committee; the UGTT mediates and guarantees; the associations document; the lawyers and journalists carry the case; and the national press and public raise the pressure. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the leverage, the union, the evidence, and the nation — the model El Kamour built.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and an occupation or a long protest tests endurance. Organise the **logistics** of a sit-in — the food, the water, the shelter, the shifts — as El Kamour sustained its desert camp. The logistics of a sustained occupation are not a detail but a determinant of success, because an occupation is a test of endurance between the community and the state, and the side that can hold out longer usually prevails. El Kamour's camp survived in the harsh desert for weeks because it was organised — supplies brought in, shifts rotated, the community's wider network keeping the occupiers fed and resupplied — and a campaign that plans this infrastructure of endurance in advance, rather than improvising it, is far more likely to outlast the authorities' patience and force the negotiation. Meet on a rhythm across the region. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — a document obtained, a union commitment, a negotiation opened, a wave of coverage. Keep the structure flat and the region united, and guard against the **division and the co-optation** — the offer of jobs or money to some, the pressure on the vulnerable — that the state or the company will use to split the

movement. Expect these efforts, because they are the standard response to a movement that cannot be broken by force: an offer of jobs to some towns but not others, a payment or a post to a prominent figure, a rumour set loose to discredit the leaders, a quiet threat to the vulnerable. The flat structure is the first defence, since there is no single leader to buy, but a campaign must also guard its unity actively — keeping every part of the region informed, insisting that any settlement serve the whole affected area and not a favoured few, and refusing to let the movement be divided into those the state has bought off and those it has not.

Phase 4: The Occupation and the Protest

Here is Tunisia's distinctive strength. Numbers and leverage, applied together, force the table. Organise the **occupation of the infrastructure or the site** — the valve, the plant, the road — that makes the project stop until the community is heard, as El Kamour shut the pumping station, and the **mass protest and sit-in** that put the region's claim before the nation. Keep it **disciplined and, where possible, peaceful**, as El Kamour's protesters chanted and sang rather than fought, because discipline protects the movement and its legitimacy, and because the state will seize on any violence to justify force. Let the **union and respected voices** stand with the community. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the companies, and the nation — that the community holds the leverage and will not release it until the powerful come to the table, as they came to El Kamour. A word on discipline is warranted, because it is where an occupation is most vulnerable: the authorities, unable to fault a peaceful and just movement, will often wait or provoke, hoping for the violence or the disorder that would justify clearing the site by force and losing the movement its public sympathy. El Kamour's protesters understood this, keeping their occupation disciplined and their protest to chants and the national anthem rather than confrontation, and a modern campaign should hold to the same discipline, treating any provocation as a trap and any lapse into violence as a gift to those who would break the movement.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE COURTS, THE LAW, AND THE NEGOTIATED AGREEMENT

Tunisia's courts offer real if slower tools, but the distinctive and often decisive instrument is the **negotiated agreement** that leverage forces — the signed commitment, guaranteed by the union, that El Kamour won. You do not need a court victory to win: an occupation that forces a fair agreement, a closure won by protest, or a permit delayed in court can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and the union early — but understand the tools.

The Negotiated Agreement

The first and most distinctive instrument is the **negotiated agreement**. Leverage — the occupied infrastructure, the sustained protest — forces the state and the companies to the table, and the prize is a **signed commitment**: jobs, a development fund, a fair share, a closure, guaranteed where possible by the **UGTT**, as the union guaranteed the El Kamour agreement. Document what is promised precisely, and treat the signed agreement as the beginning of a new fight — the fight for **implementation** — because in Tunisia the promise is often the easy part and the delivery the hard one. This point cannot be stressed enough, because it is where many Tunisian victories quietly erode. The El Kamour agreement was celebrated as a triumph, and rightly, but its terms were implemented slowly and only in part, and the region had to mount fresh protests in the years that followed — shutting the station again, blocking roads — simply to press for what had already been signed. A community that treats the signing as the end of the fight will often find, a year later, that little has changed; the agreement is a tool for the next phase of struggle, not a conclusion to it.

The Courts and the Law

The second lever is the **courts**. Tunisian courts can **review permits, defend environmental and health rights, and enforce obligations**, a real if slower tool, useful for delay, for the record, and to hold the state and companies to their commitments. Use the law on **environmental protection and public health** where a project poisons a community, as at Agareb, and the law on the region's rights where its resources are taken. A court challenge is a real front, especially to enforce an agreement the state is slow to honour.

Enforcing the Agreement

The third lever, and the one Tunisia's own experience most demands, is **enforcement**. El Kamour's agreement was implemented slowly, and the region had to rise again and again to demand what it was promised — so treat winning the agreement as half the battle, and plan from the start to **monitor, document, and enforce** it, through renewed pressure, the union, and the courts. The community that keeps its organisation alive after the signing is the one that actually

receives what it won. This is perhaps the hardest discipline of all, because the natural human impulse after a hard-won agreement is to disband, to celebrate, to return to ordinary life — and it is precisely that impulse the authorities count on when they sign a generous-looking agreement they intend to implement slowly. The El Kamour region learned this the hard way, having to reconvene and re-occupy years after the signing to force delivery of what it had already won, and the lesson for any Tunisian campaign is to keep the committee, the union alliance, and the capacity to mobilise intact long after the ink is dry.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Negotiations go through the **government and the companies, with the UGTT as mediator and guarantor**; permit and rights challenges through the **courts**; enforcement through **renewed pressure, the union, and the courts**. Get help early: Tunisia's public-interest lawyers, the UGTT, and the civil-society associations know the law, the industry, and the negotiation. Help engaged as the leverage builds is worth far more than help sought after — and in Tunisia, the strongest strategy marries the **occupation that forces the agreement** to the **union that guarantees it** and the **enforcement that delivers it**.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a minister, a union mediator, a court, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a region produces a large share of the country's oil, receives almost no jobs from it, and was promised a development fund that never came. That one fact becomes:

- **A negotiation argument:** the region is owed a fair share and the promised fund, and holds the leverage to demand them — the case El Kamour brought to the table.
- **A union argument:** the region's workers are denied the jobs and the development they were promised — the case for the UGTT to take up.
- **A legal argument:** the promises and obligations were not honoured — a ground to enforce.
- **A public argument:** our wealth leaves and we get nothing — the case that unites the region and moves the nation.
- **A national-justice argument:** the marginalised interior gives and the coast receives — the grievance the revolution made resonant.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Tunisia the arguments that most often decide things are the **leverage-and-share** one, because it forces the table, and the **harm-and-neglect** one, because it unites the region and the nation. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the revenue figures and a claim made at the table can be proven by the record; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The government at the table wants the demand framed as concrete and achievable — the jobs, the fund, the share, the closure — backed by the leverage that makes refusal costly.

The UGTT responds to the injustice to the region's workers and the case it can mediate and guarantee.

The courts want the harm or the broken promise framed against the law — the environmental and health law, the obligations — with the documents that prove it.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a poor region that shut the pipeline feeding the capital and made the state come to the desert.

The public needs the argument simple and true: our wealth leaves and we get nothing, and we will not turn it back on until we get our share.

The community itself needs to see the leverage is real and the claim is just, so it holds the occupation and stays united, as El Kamour held.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the cost of ignoring a community, brings the union and the nation in, and pressures the state to the table. El Kamour's desert occupation drew national attention precisely because it was so striking — a poor region shutting the pipeline that fed the country — and that attention was part of what forced the negotiation.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named region, a documented injustice, and a striking action. "A region is neglected" is not a story; "a desert region that produces the nation's oil, with a third of its people jobless, occupied the pumping station and shut the pipeline until the state came to the table" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the resource flow, the neglect, the occupation — and offer a human voice: a jobless young person, a protester in the camp, a union leader. In Tunisia the story of a marginalised region rising for its due, in the country that began the Arab Spring, is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and regional voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because a region's fight for its resources and its health is a national story that reaches the union, the ministries, and the public. Then the **international press and networks** — because Tunisia, the Arab Spring's democracy, draws the world's attention, which raises the pressure at home. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national ring is especially decisive** in Tunisia, because it engages the union and the government the community must bring to the table. There is a further reason national coverage matters so much in a resource-justice fight: it reframes what might otherwise look like a local disturbance as a question of national justice — whether a country should let its poorest regions produce its wealth and receive its neglect — and that framing draws in citizens far from the affected region who recognise the injustice. El Kamour's cry that the region would not give up resonated nationally because it spoke to a grievance felt across the marginalised interior, and a campaign that can make its particular fight stand for that broader justice multiplies its support.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Tunisian fight may run through a long occupation and a longer struggle for implementation. Plan a sequence — the injustice, the occupation, the negotiation, the agreement, the fight to enforce it — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; the state will seize on any exaggeration or any violence to discredit the movement, so precision and discipline protect it. Verified, specific, resource-and-justice-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped a desert sit-in force a state to the table.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you demand, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the ministries, the companies, the union, and the courts. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the leverage, the harm, and the claim.

8A. Demand to the Government / Ministry

To: the relevant ministry (energy / environment / industry) **Subject:** The demands of [region/community] regarding [project]

We, the coordination committee of [region] and [coalition], set out our demands regarding [project]: [a fair share of the region's resources / the jobs and development promised / the closure of the polluting facility]. Our region produces [X] and receives [Y]; the promises made in [agreement/date] remain unmet. We request negotiation, with the UGTT as mediator, and we are prepared to [assert our leverage] until our demands are met.

8B. Request to the UGTT

To: the UGTT (regional / national) **Subject:** Request for the union's mediation and support, [project]

We, the community of [region], ask the UGTT to **mediate and stand with us** in our fight over [project], as the union mediated and guaranteed the El Kamour agreement. Our region is denied [its share / jobs / a clean environment], and the promises made to it are unmet. We attach our evidence and ask for the union's support in forcing and guaranteeing a fair agreement.

8C. Letter to the Company

To: the operating company **Subject:** The obligations of [company] to [region]

We write regarding [company]'s operations in [region]. The region that bears your project receives [almost none of its jobs / a poisoned environment / none of the promised development]. We call on you to meet your obligations to the region — [the jobs, the development, the environmental protection] — and we advise that the community will [assert its leverage] until they are met.

8D. Objection / Environmental-Health Complaint

To: the environmental authority / the courts **Subject:** Harm to health and environment from [project]

We, the community of [place], report that [project] causes [the pollution, the poisoned air or water, the health toll], documented and attached. As at Agareb, a facility that poisons its community must be held to account and, where the harm is grave, **closed**. We demand inspection, enforcement, and the protection of our health and environment.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Association

To: a public-interest lawyer / civil-society association **Subject:** [Project] — the claim, the harm, and the agreement

We are fighting [project] over [the region's share / the harm to our health / the broken promises]. We attach the permits, the revenue and employment figures, our evidence of harm, and any agreement, and seek advice on **enforcing the region's rights and any agreement, challenging the harm in court, and defending our right to protest**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8F. Demand for Implementation of an Agreement

To: the government / the companies (with the UGTT) **Subject:** Implement the [agreement/date] for [region]

We, the community of [region], demand the **full implementation** of the [agreement] signed on [date], which promised [the jobs, the fund, the development]. As with El Kamour, the promise has not been kept, and the region has waited too long. We require a timetable and delivery, guaranteed by the UGTT, and we are prepared to renew our pressure until the agreement is honoured.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the region / the occupation]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something the nation should know, with a clear hook: [documents and figures] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a region produces much of the country's oil, has a third of its people jobless, and shut the pipeline until the state came to the table"]. It echoes El Kamour. I can share the full file and connect you with a protester and a union leader. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Region] demands its due from [project]

We, the community of [region], declare that we will no longer give our wealth and receive neglect. [Project] takes [the resources of our land / poisons our air and water] while we have [no work / no health / no development]. We hold the leverage, and we will not release it until the state and the companies meet us at the table, as they met El Kamour. We demand [the share, the jobs, the fund, the closure], and we will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a demand, an objection, or a request for the union's mediation is itself evidence, and exactly what the ministries, the union, and the courts will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the leverage, the harm, and the claim; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the flat committee, the UGTT, the associations, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the agreement, becomes part of your record, and in Tunisia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the occupation that forces the table, the union that guarantees the deal, and the enforcement that delivers it. In practice these three fit together as a sequence a community should plan from the start: the occupation or protest applies the pressure that forces the table; the union brokers and guarantees the agreement that the pressure wins; and the sustained organisation, backed by the courts and the threat of renewed protest, enforces the agreement over the years it takes to become real. A campaign that plans only for the first, the dramatic occupation, and neglects the second and third will win a headline and lose the substance; the El Kamour region's long experience is the proof that the fight for delivery is as important as the fight for the deal.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project — and force a fair share. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find your leverage.** In Tunisia, leverage forces the table. Identify what the community can occupy or withhold — the valve, the site, the road, the labour (Step 1).
- 2. Organise flat.** Build a coordination committee with no single leader to arrest or buy, spread across the region (Step 3).
- 3. Bring in the UGTT.** Ask the union to mediate, guarantee, and stand with you (8B) — Tunisia's distinctive ally.
- 4. Document the injustice.** Record what the region gives, what it is denied, and what it was promised (Step 2).
- 5. Occupy or protest.** Assert the leverage — the sit-in, the occupation, the mass protest — that makes the powerful come to the table (Step 3).
- 6. Force and guarantee the agreement.** Negotiate a signed commitment, guaranteed by the union (8A, 8F).
- 7. Enforce it.** Keep organising after the signing, because the promise is the easy part (8F).

Do only the first three and you will have found your leverage, organised to resist repression, and brought in the union — the exact foundation of El Kamour. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: find the leverage, organise flat, bring in the union.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Tunisia's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real and, in recent years, sharper. The **marginalised interior and south** have long given their resources to a **coastal capital** that returns little — the very grievance that drove the revolution and El Kamour. **Implementation of agreements is slow**, so a signed promise is not a delivered one. **Protest can be dangerous**, met by the army and the police, and people have been hurt and killed. And since 2021 the **democratic space has narrowed**, so the civic freedoms a community relies on — to protest, to organise, to speak — cannot be taken for granted. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes an easy protest or a self-executing agreement will be disappointed.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real and distinctive levers remain.

Leverage still forces the table. A community that can occupy the infrastructure or withhold the labour still holds a power the state must answer, as El Kamour did.

The UGTT still matters. The union remains a powerful national force that can mediate, guarantee, and lend organised strength.

Flat organisation still resists repression. A movement with no single leader to arrest or buy is harder to break.

The claim to resources and health still unites. A region's demand for its share and its health is a cause the revolution made resonant, and one that still moves the nation.

The world still watches. Tunisia, the Arab Spring's democracy, draws an international attention that raises the cost of repression.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Tunisia is realistic but far from hopeless: the space has narrowed and the wins may be partial and slow, but leverage, the union, flat organisation, and a just claim still give a community real and distinctive power. So diagnose your fight honestly: find your **leverage**; organise **flat and disciplined**; bring in the **UGTT**; assert the leverage through **occupation and protest**; force and **enforce the agreement**; and where a full stop or a clean win is out of reach, pursue the fair share, the closure, or the concession that leverage can win. Do not assume the protest will be easy or the promise self-keeping; organise for the danger and for the long fight to enforce what you win. Both cautions come from Tunisia's own recent experience rather than from any abstract pessimism: people have been injured and killed in these confrontations, and agreements celebrated as victories have taken years of renewed pressure to be honoured even in part. A community that goes in clear-eyed about both — preparing for the possibility of a hard state response, and building the endurance to keep fighting long after the signing — is far better placed than one that expects an easy protest and a self-keeping promise, and it is that realism, as much as any tactic, that separates the campaigns that ultimately deliver for their people from those that win a moment and lose the substance.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Tunisia has real concerns about how contracts are awarded, how resources are managed, and how the wealth of a region can flow to connected interests, so this section matters. When a project's benefits are captured — the resources of a region enriching the connected while the region gets neglect — your strategy includes exposing that capture.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A region's **resources enriching the capital and connected interests** while the region gets nothing; **contracts awarded** opaquely or to the connected; **revenues that vanish** without reaching the people whose land produced them; **promises made and broken** with impunity; and **officials who profit** from the arrangement. Trace the resources and the money: what the region produces, where the wealth goes, who benefits. In Tunisia, a region that gives its wealth and receives neglect is often not an accident but an arrangement that serves the connected — exactly the injustice El Kamour rose against.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Officials, parts of the administration, and connected companies** can be captured by the arrangement. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **UGTT**, a powerful independent union; the **courts**, slower but real; **civil society and the associations**; the **independent and international press**; and the **organised, mobilised community**, which holds the leverage. Capture thrives on a region's silence and disorganisation; your task is to organise the region, document where its wealth goes, and force the arrangement into the light — to the union, the courts, the press, and the nation.

What to Do

Do not assume the arrangement cannot be touched. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — what the region produces, where the wealth goes, who benefits, what was promised and broken — and take it to the forces that can act: the **UGTT**, to mediate and pressure; the **courts**, to enforce obligations; the **independent and international press**; and the **nation**, whose sense of justice the revolution sharpened. Pair the exposure with the community's leverage — the occupation, the protest — so the injustice and the pressure arrive together. In Tunisia, exposing how a region's wealth is captured while it bears neglect strips the arrangement of legitimacy and strengthens the community's hand at the table,

as El Kamour turned a documented injustice into a signed agreement. The anti-corruption angle strengthens a resource-justice fight in a particular way: it shifts the moral ground entirely, so that the community is no longer asking for a favour but exposing a wrong, and the state is no longer generously conceding but being held to account for an arrangement it cannot defend in the open. A region whose wealth vanishes into connected pockets while its people go without work has a grievance that, once documented and publicised, is very hard for any government to justify, and pairing that exposure with the community's leverage is among the most powerful combinations available in the Tunisian system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Tunisia turns on the leverage, the union, and the enforcement.

Early (Months 0-6): Leverage, Organisation, and the Union

Pin down the project and the community's leverage (Step 1); document the harm, the neglect, and the broken promises (Step 2). Build the **flat coordination committee** across the region (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **bring in the UGTT** (8B); **set out the demands** to the government and the company (8A, 8C); and prepare the **occupation or protest** and its logistics (Step 3). Reach **lawyers, associations, and journalists** early (8E, 8G). This phase lays the foundation, and in Tunisia the leverage, the flat organisation, and the union brought in here are what make the negotiation possible.

Middle (Months 3-18): Occupy, Protest, and Negotiate

Sustain the committee and the region's unity (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Assert the leverage — the **occupation, the sit-in, the mass protest** — and open the **negotiation** with the union as mediator (Step 3, Step 4). Build the media drumbeat from regional to national to international (Step 5). Force the **signed agreement** — the jobs, the fund, the share, the closure. Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — the occupation while the leverage is strongest, the union brought in before the talks — because those chances do not return.

Later (Months 6-36+): Enforce, and Hold

Win the agreement — and then fight the longer battle to **enforce** it, because, as at El Kamour, the promise is often slow to become delivery, and the region must keep its organisation alive to receive what it won (Step 4). And stay vigilant, because a government may let an agreement lapse, and a region must be ready to renew its pressure. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped or a facility closed. Sometimes it is a fair share and a fund, won and then enforced over years. Both are victories worth the fight. And there is a further value in even the partial wins: each documented case of a region forcing the state to the table, each agreement wrung out and then enforced, builds a precedent and a confidence that outlast the single fight, teaching the next marginalised region that its wealth is a source of leverage and its organisation a source of power. El Kamour itself drew on the memory of earlier protests in the mining basin and the revolution, and it has in turn become a reference for communities across the country; a movement is part of a lineage, and even a fight that wins only a share leaves the next one better armed.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-6	Find the leverage Document harm + neglect Build the flat committee Bring in the UGTT Set out demands
MONTHS 3-18	Occupy / protest Negotiate with the union Media Force the signed agreement
MONTHS 6-36+	Enforce the agreement Keep the organisation alive Guard against lapse

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Tunisia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Occupying the infrastructure** forces the state and the companies to the table, as El Kamour shut the pipeline. **The UGTT and organised labour** mediate, guarantee, and lend a strength few movements anywhere can call on. **Non-hierarchical organisation** resists the repression that breaks leader-based movements. **Mass protest and the sit-in**, in the country that began the Arab Spring, are a practised and potent lever. And the **claim to a**

region's resources and health unites the community and moves the nation. These are the tools that let a poor desert region make the state come to it. They are, notably, tools that do not depend on wealth, on powerful patrons, or on a friendly government — a region with almost nothing but its grip on the infrastructure, its capacity to organise, and the justice of its claim used them to prevail — which is why they travel to almost any Tunisian community willing to take them up.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. El Kamour **won a share, not a stop**; agreements are **slowly implemented**; protest can be **dangerous**; and the **civic space has narrowed**. No guide should pretend these away; in Tunisia, the art is to win what leverage can win — a stop, a closure, or a fair share — and then to fight the long fight to enforce it.

So the realistic promise is this: **find your leverage; organise flat and disciplined; bring in the UGTT; assert the leverage through occupation and protest; force the signed agreement; and enforce it over the long haul — running all of it together**. Do that, and where a community holds real leverage and organises well, you can stop a project, close a poisoning facility, or force a fair share of your region's wealth, as El Kamour did; where you hold less, you can still win delay, a partial concession, and a record. Do it as El Kamour did — a poor region that organised without arrestable leaders, brought in the union, occupied the pipeline, and made the state sign.

A last word on leverage and endurance. Tunisia's lesson is that an organised community holds more power than the powerful want it to believe — that a region which gives its wealth can reach into the pipeline and force the state to the table — but that the prize is often a share and a promise, and the promise must then be fought for, year after year, until it becomes real. The powerful count on your resignation, on your disorganisation, on the belief that your wealth must leave and you must receive nothing. Their advantage is the capital's distance and the slow grinding of unkept promises. Yours is the infrastructure you can hold, a union that can guarantee your agreement, a way of organising they cannot easily break, and the proven fact that El Kamour made the state come to the desert. Play to that. Keep the record and the leverage, keep the region united and the structure flat, bring in the union, occupy where you must, and treat every occupation, every agreement, and every enforced promise as a brick in a wall no arrangement can climb.

The tools are here, and Tunisia itself proved them: a poor desert region, organising without leaders a government could arrest, occupied the pipeline that fed the capital and forced the state and the companies to sign for its jobs, its fund, and its due. What decides the outcome, in the end, is leverage, organisation, endurance, and a community that refuses to give its wealth for nothing — and those you supply. Begin today, begin with your leverage and your flat committee, and build from there. Communities before you have made the powerful come to them — a pipeline shut, an agreement signed, a region's due wrested from a distant capital. They did it not with money or connections but with organisation, leverage, and the plain justice of a region asking for a share of what its own land produces, and they did it in the knowledge that the promise, once signed, would still have to be fought for — and they fought for it. What El Kamour won can be won again. So can yours. A poor and forgotten region, with a third of its people out of work and its wealth flowing past it to the coast, organised itself so that no leader could be picked off, reached the one point where it could halt the machine, and refused to let go until the state and the companies met it as equals at the table. That is the resistance available to a Tunisian community that knows its leverage and holds its nerve, and the method behind it, and the proof that it works, are now yours to use.